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Isabela Fairclough and Norman Fairclough, *Political Discourse Analysis: A Method for Advanced Students*, Abingdon: Routledge, 2012; x + 266 pp., ISBN 978-0-415-49922-4, US$38.95 (hbk).

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In recent decades practitioners of critical discourse analysis (CDA) have made continuous efforts to draw insights from other theories and disciplines in social and political science, and this new book by Isabela Fairclough and Norman Fairclough represents a recent achievement in this direction. Political discourse analysis (PDA) refers to 'the analysis of the political discourse from a critical perspective' (p. 17), and this book presents a method which is distinctive for its emphasis on the special nature of political discourse and the proposed integrated analytic framework which brings together concepts in CDA with argumentation theory. It argues that what distinguishes political discourse from other fields of discourse is its apparent 'deliberative' and 'argumentative' nature (i.e. decision-making about what to do), so a new approach to PDA should go beyond the traditional focus on ways of 'representation' to the focus on 'decision-making' or 'action'. This suggests the relevance of argumentation theory to PDA, contributing to a novel interdisciplinary collaboration which has not been undertaken in other books.

The book is organized into eight chapters, including six main chapters, plus an introduction and a conclusion. The introductory chapter informs readers of the main ideas of this book with a brief discussion of the relevance of argumentation theory in the study of accounts of the financial and economic crisis in Britain. The next six main chapters can be divided into two parts. The first three chapters are concerned with theoretical issues, while the remaining three focus on case studies. Chapter 1 identifies the niche for this new approach to PDA through reviewing existing approaches to PDA and the literature on the nature of politics in political theory. Chapter 2 is devoted to the development of a new framework for the analysis and evaluation of practical argumentation. It identifies four premises – goal, value, circumstantial, and means–end – for the analysis of the structure of a practical argument, and then discusses the possible perspectives from which a practical argument can be evaluated. Chapter 3 explicates how argumentation analysis can be incorporated into CDA, thus enhancing its analytic capacity. It first introduces an approach to CDA developed by Norman Fairclough as well as its relations to critical social science. Then it discusses the possible contributions of argumentation analysis and evaluation to CDA in terms of textual analysis, normative and explanatory critique (i.e. critique of manipulation and ideology) and three important concepts in CDA (imaginaries, political legitimacy and power).

Chapters 4, 5 and 6 form the second part, in which this new analytic framework is applied to the analysis of British responses to the financial and economic crisis in different contexts. Chapter 4 presents a holistic picture of how this new integrated framework can be applied through the respective analysis of two British policy-making texts: a Pre-Budget Report and a Budget Report. It not only analyzes the argumentation strategies

and premises in each report, but also critically evaluates them in terms of the responses of relevant participants such as politicians, economists and journalists. Chapter 5 is dedicated to the significant role of values in argumentation by looking at a public debate over whether or not bankers should continue to receive bonuses in times of economic crisis. It exposes competing claims for action motivated by either 'interest' (Prudential argument) or 'moral-political values' such as justice and equality (Moral argument). Chapter 6 is devoted to the analysis of deliberation as a genre in the special context of parliamentary debate, where different parties have to work to arrive at a decision. Taking the debate on university tuition fees as an example, it demonstrates how deliberation in this special activity type can be critically analyzed through reconstructing it as 'critical discussion', identifying its institutional constraints, and mapping the structure of argumentation. Finally, the book is brought to a brief conclusion by summarizing its main points and identifying its main contributions to several fields and disciplines such as argumentation theory and analysis, CDA and PDA.

This book is innovative and significant in several aspects. First and foremost, it seeks to distinguish political discourse from other fields of discourse, and thus sets a new agenda for PDA, that is, to study political discourse as 'action' or 'decision-making' rather than 'representations'. The integrated analytic framework established in this book represents the so-called 'interdisciplinary' endeavor (Fairclough, 2003), which draws insights from both argumentation theory and CDA, and, at the same time, contributes to the development of both disciplines. As an intended handbook of PDA for advanced students, this book is also noted for its clear points, smooth and coherent organization, and rich and illuminating demonstrations. It will benefit both students and researchers who are interested in CDA, PDA, argumentation analysis, communication studies, and other related disciplines, even though a basic knowledge of CDA and argumentation theory is required for the understanding of this book. However, since it deals only with the genres of Budget Report and debate and the modality of language, further applications of this approach to other genres in the political context and to other semiotic modalities are expected. It is believed that this book will lead to more studies following this direction and contribute to the future development of CDA.

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Reference

Fairclough N (2003) *Discourse Analysis: Textual Analysis for Social Research*. London: SAGE.